

JON BAKER

Jon Baker Rewrites the Marinha Record Book

Jon Baker's 89 gross eclipses the previous Quinta da Marinha record of 91, and the 35 Stableford points that came with it were also the best return of the day.

Jon Baker played the best round of the day at Quinta da Marinha. His gross 89 is a new course record. The previous mark of 91 had stood across six prior visits, largely undisturbed, because nobody had shown much appetite for disturbing it. It was also Baker's personal best at the venue, three shots inside his previous visit, and comfortably his best gross of the trip.

The record did not arrive unblemished. From the 7th to the 9th he went three holes

without a net par. A bogey first. Then a double at the par-4 8th, the hardest hole on the course. Then another double at the par-3 9th. He steadied himself with back-to-back pars at the 12th and 13th. The par at the 12th, against one of the toughest indexes out there, drew him level for the lead in the 2015 Green Jacket (Gross). By the close he had gone two clear of David Mullin. Mullin's six-shot lead had vanished entirely.

AT A GLANCE
ROUND OF THE DAY Jon BAKER (35 pts)
TROPHY LEAD Gregg WILLIAMS, 5 ahead
GREEN JACKET LEAD Jon BAKER, 2 ahead

ROUND STABLEFORD
JB 35 HM 34 AB 32 GW 29 DM 26 SN 20
ROUND GROSS
JB +18 HM +24 DM +26 GW +35 AB +40 SN +43

AFTER R3 • TROPHY
GW 108 JB 103 AB 98 DM 92 HM 90 SN 68
AFTER R3 • GREEN JACKET
JB +58 DM +60 HM +83 GW +85 SN +113 AB +115

SIDEBAR

Mullin's Long Reign Ends at the 13th

A 36-hole grip on the Green Jacket lead evaporates at the same hole it was won, and the Trophy leader's cushion is cut in half without losing top spot.

David Mullin had led the 2015 Green Jacket (Gross) since the 13th hole of the first round. It ended at Quinta da Marinha, at the 13th. A different hole on a different course, sharing only a number, which is the sort of symmetry that consoles nobody standing inside it. Jon Baker moved ahead there. Mullin drew level once more

at the 15th, and that was the last encouraging thing to happen to him. He closed with 26 points, his worst round of the tournament and a 10-shot drop from Round 2's 36. Baker's 89 gross was his own course best this TEG.

Gregg Williams held on to his 2015 Trophy lead. He held on to rather less of his cushion, which fell

from 11 points to 5. Williams shed 14 shots across holes 8 to 11, a stretch capped by a quintuple bogey 10 at the par-5 11th. His 29 points were a 12-shot fall from a strong Round 2. He still leads. He may prefer not to look behind him. And Baker goes into the weekend out in front of the Green Jacket race.

WOODEN SPOON

Neumann's Spoon Grip Tightens Further

Five holes without a net par and two blow-up tens turn a modest overnight cushion into a 22-point gap at the bottom of the pile.

Stuart Neumann's Round 3 at Quinta da Marinha unravelled early and never recovered. He opened with a 10 at the par-5 1st, a quintuple bogey. Then a double at the 2nd. Then a double at the 3rd. Then a quintuple bogey 9 at the par-4 4th, and a triple at the 5th. Seventeen shots dropped across five holes, with not one net par among them.

There was no respite at the turn. A quintuple bogey 8 came at the par-3 9th. A par-3 taken in 8 is not a golf hole. It is an occupation. An 11 followed at the par-5 10th, a sextuple bogey on one of the course's harder holes, then a double at the 11th. Another three holes, another absence of net pars.

The round produced 20 Stableford points, the worst in the field. In Round 2 he had posted 31. He remains anchored to the bottom of the 2015 TEG Wooden Spoon standings, his gap to the next-worst player stretched from 8 points to 22. He is no longer losing that race. He is conducting it alone.

ALEX BAKER

Wreckage and a New Best for Alex Baker

Three straight triples and a sextuple-bogey ten still leave Alex Baker one shot better than his only previous visit to Quinta da Marinha.

Alex Baker's third round at Quinta da Marinha became a survival exercise. The trouble began at the par-5 3rd and showed no interest in leaving. Triple bogeys at the 3rd, 4th and 5th cost nine shots in three holes. A double at the 7th then ran straight into a sextuple-bogey ten at the par-4 8th, the hardest hole on the course. Further double and triple bogeys at the 9th and 10th completed a 13-shot stretch across four holes. The quadruple bogey at the 12th, the second-hardest hole, was almost a formality by then. He stopped the bleeding himself with a birdie at the 17th.

None of it derailed the bigger picture. Baker's gross beat his previous best at Quinta da Marinha, set on his only prior visit, by a single stroke. A personal best, with a ten on the card. That is broadly what progress looks like round here.

RECORDS & PERSONAL BESTS

Notable achievements: TEG 8, Round 3

PERSONAL WORSTS

— David Mullin's worst round to date: 26 pts

RARE FEATS

— Stuart Neumann runs up an 8 (+5) at the 9th — his career-worst on a par-3